INDIA TODAY CONCLAVE 2026 MUMBAI

GATEWA

THE INDIA TODAY CONCLAVE IN MUMBAI EXP

On October 9 and 10, while Mumbai was grappling with one of the hottest spells for those dates in over a decade, the country was gripped by protests in Delhi demanding the removal of chief election commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar. The issue featured prominently at the India Today Conclave in Mumbai, where nearly 70 speakers from politics, business, defence, entertainment, science and culture debated a range of pressing concerns.

In the session titled 'Maha Model for a Maha India', Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnavis accused the Cockroach Janta Party of exploiting the political vacuum left by the Opposition and denied that public sentiment was turning against the BJP. The Election Commission (EC), however, became a flashpoint. While Union minister Kiren Rijiju said, "We are not defending the people sitting in the EC alone, we are defending the institution," Congress general secretary Sachin Pilot vowed to continue protests demanding the CEC's resignation. Former CEC O.P. Rawat and former election commissioner Ashok Lavasa questioned the Special Intensive Revision process, raising concerns about procedural irregularities and eligible voters whose appeals against deletion remained unresolved. NCP(SCP) working president Supriya Sule called for comprehensive electoral reforms, while rejecting speculation about an alliance with the BJP.

In a session on India's economic roadmap, J.P. Morgan chief India economist Sajjid Z. Chinoy warned that our increasingly capital-intensive growth was limiting employment generation. SBI group chief economic adviser Soumya Kanti Ghosh highlighted investment in data centres, renewable energy and healthcare. But economist Ajit Ranade cautioned that rapid growth was accompanied by rising inequality, while Bank of Baroda chief economist Madan Sabnavis called for stronger MSMEs and agricultural commercialisation.

Former NITI Aayog member Dr V.K. Saraswat stressed indigenous technology and missile defence as strategic necessities. Western Naval Command flag officer commanding-in-chief Vice Admiral Sanjay Vatsayan discussed maritime preparedness and the growing weaponisation of geography.

In the pages that follow, we bring you some of the high points of the conclave. ■

–M.G. Arun



"The biggest challenge is tackling this year's drought. Almost 75% of Maharashtra is suffering from crop losses...drinking water will be a problem, as will fodder for livestock"

DEVENDRA FADNAVIS
Chief Minister, Maharashtra

Photographs by **CHANDRADEEP KUMAR, MANDAR DEODHAR**